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SU V1 V2 V3 V4

 **Rain 41/38** • Tomorrow: Thunderstorm 65/32 **B6** *Democracy Dies in Darkness* SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 15, 2025 • **\$4**

A possible miscue on a key tower directive

NTSB says Black Hawk crew might have missed ‘pass behind’ command

BY DANIEL GILBERT
AND RACHEL WEINER

The crew of an Army Black Hawk helicopter might not have heard key instructions from air traffic control before a collision with a passenger jet over the Potomac River on Jan. 29, the National Transportation Safety Board said Friday in its most detailed account of the moments before the crash that killed 67 people.

About 17 seconds before the helicopter and plane collided, air traffic control had directed the Black Hawk's crew to “pass behind the CRJ,” referring to the type of American Airlines regional jet that was approaching Reagan National Airport.

Jennifer Homendy, NTSB's chairman, said Friday that “‘pass behind the’ may not have been received by the crew,” based on its review of the Black Hawk's cockpit voice recorder, which did not capture those words. The helicopter crew had activated its microphone at that moment to communicate with air traffic control.

She also disclosed that the investigation has uncovered discrepancies in verbal readouts of altitude called out by the Black Hawk crew as they flew south along the Potomac. Conflicting readings could provide clues as to why the helicopter was flying above its mandatory 200-foot ceiling before the crash at 8:47 p.m. southeast of the airport.

NTSB disclosed the details during a minute-by-minute account of the rapidly developing disaster. At the last moment before impact, the passenger jet

SEE DCA ON A2

Republicans scramble to save USAID food program

BY ANNIE GOWEN,
ABIGAIL HAUSLOHNER
AND KATHARINE HOURELD

As GOP lawmakers in Washington try to protect a key food aid program from the Trump administration's cutbacks, international humanitarian organizations say the ongoing disruptions in assistance are devastating countries that are on the verge of famine.

The administration's move in late January to gut the U.S. Agency for International Development — laying off thousands of workers and freezing funding in more than 100 countries — immediately jeopardized Food for Peace. For more than 70 years, the \$2 billion program has purchased surplus commodities from American farmers for distribution overseas.

Late Thursday, U.S. District Judge Amir Ali ordered administration officials to temporarily lift their freeze on U.S. aid and development programs abroad. He alluded to the “shockwave” caused by their action and said they “have not offered any explanation for why a blanket suspension of all congressionally appropriated foreign aid ... was a rational precur-

SEE FOOD FOR PEACE ON A6

At Chernobyl nuclear site, a close call



SERGEY DOLZHENKO/EPA-EFE/SHUTTERSTOCK

A Ukrainian soldier directs a light toward a protective shelter at the Chernobyl nuclear site that Kyiv officials say was hit early Friday by a Russian drone. The strike caused a fire but radiation levels remained normal, according to Ukrainian and international atomic energy officials. The New Safe Confinement structure houses the remains of the Chernobyl No. 4 reactor, which exploded in April 1986 in the world's worst nuclear disaster. **Story, A9**

DOJ files to drop case after 7 prosecutors refused

Showdown over charges against NYC mayor adds to concerns about Justice

BY JEREMY ROEBUCK,
SHAYNA JACOBS,
MARK BERMAN
AND CAROL D. LEONNIG

The Justice Department on Friday filed a motion to drop corruption charges against New York Mayor Eric Adams, leaving it to a federal judge to decide the fate of a case that has ignited a dramatic standoff between the Trump administration and veteran prosecutors in two cities.

The motion, filed in a New York court, was signed by acting deputy attorney general Emil Bove; Edward Sullivan, a veteran public corruption prosecutor; and Toni

FROM HAGAN SCOTTEN'S RESIGNATION LETTER

“But any assistant U.S. attorney would know that our laws and traditions do not allow using the prosecutorial power to influence other citizens, much less elected officials, in this way. If no lawyer within earshot of the President is willing to give him that advice, then I expect you will eventually find someone who is enough of a fool, or enough of a coward, to file your motion. But it was never going to be me.”

Bacon, acting chief of the Justice Department's criminal division, after seven other Justice Department lawyers had refused and resigned in protest.

Bove instructed prosecutors in

New York on Monday to drop the charges, saying the case could interfere with the mayor's reelection bid and his efforts to work with the Trump administration on immigration enforcement. He said his

decision was not based on a consideration of the evidence or the legal theories underpinning the case.

Danielle Sassoon, acting U.S. attorney for the Southern District of New York, quit instead and accused President Donald Trump's appointees of acting for political, rather than legal, reasons. Nearly all of the supervisors within the Justice Department's public integrity section followed suit.

The tensions only grew Friday, as the lead prosecutor on the case in New York, Hagan Scotten, submitted his resignation, calling any lawyer who would ask a judge to toss the charges a “fool” or “coward.”

Bove, meanwhile, summoned the roughly two dozen remaining members of the public integrity

SEE RESIGNATIONS ON A4

Job cuts: Targeted positions police misdeeds and support workers. **A5**

In the West, manifest destiny with a modern twist

Sale of federal land could boost Las Vegas's housing market, an idea Trump may gamble on



LOUIS GRASSE FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Housing costs in Las Vegas have boomed in recent years as demand has grown and space has dwindled.

BY RACHEL SIEGEL

LAS VEGAS — In a city where housing costs are rising like a roulette jackpot, the 195 new apartments at Heirloom at Pebble are filling a crucial gap. But it's really the land beneath this complex for low-income seniors — five acres of dirt and rock, all of which used to belong to the federal government — that could become part of the national playbook to build more homes.

With the Trump administration back in power in Washington, politicians, local home builders and residents are eying massive tracts of government-owned land to relieve housing costs across the West. That attention is especially fixed on Nevada — where more than 80 percent of the land is controlled by the U.S. government — and on Las Vegas, which recently posted the fourth-highest annual home price

SEE HOUSING ON A16

Vance exports MAGA message

CHIDES AUDIENCE OF EUROPEAN LEADERS

He finds common cause with anti-migrant parties

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM,
CAT ZAKRZEWSKI
AND ELLEN FRANCIS

MUNICH — JD Vance made his vice-presidential debut on the global security stage Friday in a scolding speech here, pressing Europe's centrist leaders to move over to accommodate the rising anti-migration, nationalist voices they have at times sought to block from power.

Vance also met with Alice Weidel, head of the nationalist Alternative for Germany party, becoming the most senior U.S. official to do so. He also met in recent days with the leaders of Germany's two other major parties, which are locked in competition ahead of the Feb. 23 elections in which Weidel's party is trying to break through a post-World War II taboo and join a ruling coalition for the first time.

In his speech, Vance fully waded into nationalist politics, blasting an audience of European prime ministers and presidents for failing to listen to their own voters. His remarks amounted to an attempt to export MAGA to Europe — and a declaration of common cause with rising anti-migrant parties in Europe, who, like Trump, are skeptical of international alliances and many of the hallmarks of the global system that developed in the aftermath of World War II and expanded after the fall of communism.

SEE VANCE ON A5

Today's WorldView: For Trump's deals, humans are a nuisance. **A9**

Federal staff firings may soon imperil services

BY HANNAH NATANSON,
EMILY DAVIES, LISA REIN
AND RACHEL SIEGEL

The Trump administration's move to fire thousands of federal employees could have a swift and severe impact on public services, staffers warned Friday, making it harder for veterans to get mental health care and hampering electric service to some rural residents as a beleaguered workforce struggles to cover for lost colleagues.

The full impact of the terminations will not be fully known for weeks or months, and some job losses may be reversed or challenged by law. At least one agency, the Department of Energy, paused some cuts to assess their effect on nuclear defense programs, according to three people who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss internal deliberations. Still, workers said basic functions at many agencies are slowing almost immediately and could break down as critical colleagues are shown the door.

On Friday, dozens of federal

SEE FIRINGS ON A5

Camera-ready: Md. photographer gives federal workers headshots. **B1**

IN THE NEWS

Heating up Two new studies suggest that a decline in cloud cover has ignited a feedback loop that has exacerbated warming, helping explain the past two years of record heat. **A9**

Self-defense plea denied A Maryland funeral director was convicted of killing a pallbearer during a child's ceremony at a cemetery. **B1**

THE NATION
Health agencies were ordered to post notices rebuking “gender ideology” on restored sites. **A3**
A wave of cuts at the Education Department targeted contracts, staff and grants. **A6**

THE WORLD
A kayaker survived being briefly scooped up in a whale's mouth off Chile's coast. **A7**
South Korea's likely next leader wants warmer ties with North Korea and China. **A10**

THE ECONOMY
The disappearance of an animal microchip company — and its data — has worried pet owners seeking answers. **A11**
Thousands of employees at the Internal Revenue Service face layoffs as the U.S. DOGE Service takes aim at tax collections. **A12**

THE REGION
D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser wants an NFL stadium at the RFK site, but residents and council members aren't all on the same sideline. **B1**
A report explained how Richmond descended into a water crisis during a snowstorm and suggested safeguards. **B1**

STYLE
An obscure court decision involving Sean Spicer was key in helping Trump take control of the Kennedy Center. **C1**

SPORTS
Alex Sarr, the Wizards' rookie center, has the freedom to fail and no fear in doing so. **D1**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A11
COMICS.....C7
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A13
TELEVISION.....C6
WORLD NEWS.....A7

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